



Sony blocks 'cross-consoling'

Sony's continued refusal to allow for cross-console play has become an absolute trend in recent months. <http://digit.in/PS4only>



A Buddhist priest robot

A Japanese company has introduced a new role for SoftBank's humanoid robot "Pepper" - a Buddhist priest for hire. <http://digit.in/Pepper2>

MSI Vortex G65VR 6RF

The unconventional gaming PC

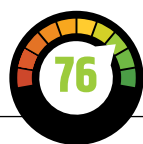
To be fair, this is not really an original design since Apple already made a cylindrical PC back in 2013, with the Mac Pro. However, Apple would be the first to point out that the Mac Pro is a Mac, not a PC. The Vortex, however is not just a PC, but a gaming PC at that. It has the same upgradability restrictions as the Mac Pro, but the Vortex packs more powerful hardware in this cylindrical chassis.

Build and Design

The cylindrical design does suggest an Apple Mac Pro lineage, but MSI has changed some things to incorporate all that top shelf gaming hardware into a reasonably tiny 6.5L chassis. The outside shell is made out of a plastic composite and feels metallic to touch. It seems durable as well, although only long term users will be able to shed more light on that.

While the outside of the desktop looks absolutely amazing, what is far more awe-inspiring is how hardware is packed inside. The internal layout of the Vortex resembles a similar assembly to the 2013 Mac Pro, with its custom 450W 80 plus gold PSU, fixed in the middle of the triangular frame. It is flanked by the CPU on one side, while the other has the custom, yet still desktop grade, NVIDIA GeForce GTX 1080 GPU. The third side of the triangular frame carries the two NVMe SSDs, which come pre-configured in RAID4. This third side of the frame can actually house a second GPU, as in some markets the machine is sold with two NVIDIA GPUs in SLI. In India it is repurposed for the SSDs.

Talking about cooling, the entire chassis is solely cooled by a single fan at the top and from what we have



FEATURE.....	64
PERFORMANCE.....	85
VALUE.....	56
DESIGN.....	98

observed, it does a really good job at cooling the unit.

Performance

The MSI Vortex G65 has an extremely powerful resume and the performance figures are in line with that. The Intel core 7700K combined with the NVIDIA GeForce GTX

1080 allows the user to play all its favourite games at the highest settings in 1080p. The machine will also run all AAA titles and demanding games in 2K effortlessly. To ensure optimal performance on 2k, it is better to have a G-Sync ready monitor, that will allow for consistent frame rates across games respectively.

Games like Battlefield 1 ran flawlessly in 1080p, pushing 80+ fps with DX12 enabled at ultra settings, without any hiccups. Going up to 2K resolution, the fps counter averaged at 58fps at ultra settings. It was only when I switched to a 4K display that the FPS counter tumbled down to below 50fps. However, even at 4K, the machine maintained an average frame rate of 46fps. More recent

games like Dishonored 2 also ran smoothly, chugging out more than 60fps even at 4K. I also tested some older titles, such as Metro Last light, which also ran happily at 125fps and 95fps, at 1080p and 2K resolutions respectively.

The Vortex's powerful performance is further seconded by the synthetic benchmark figures. The machine scored 6029 points on PCMark 8 Creative. It performed quite well on Cinebench 15, which is a good test for graphics performance. The Vortex scored 150.65fps.

Bottomline

The biggest competitor to the MSI Vortex G65 VR is the Asus ROG G20CB, which is another small pre-configured NVIDIA GeForce GTX 1080 powered PC, available off the shelf. It features pretty much the same hardware and is cheaper too. However, the G20CB misses out on some key I/O ports and is not as over-clockable as the Vortex.

This means, that the synthetic benchmark scores are marginally higher than the Asus ROG G20CB. We presume that the higher performance from the Vortex could be due to newer drivers and the fact that it runs the latest version of Windows 10, but admittedly we're a bit uncertain about that at the moment.

Moreover, you can definitely get better performance out of an assembled custom PC with off the shelf parts. That would be advisable if you are looking to overclock, and cheaper to build as well. However, you won't get the small footprint and the swag factor the Vortex G65 comes with, which is something you can only get by paying the premium.

—Hardik Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

CPU: Intel Core i7-7700K | GPU: NVIDIA GeForce GTX 1080 | CHIPSET: Z170 | RAM: 8GB DDR4 RAM | OS: Windows 10 | I/O: Gigabit Ethernet, 4x USB 3.0, 2x USB Type C, Audio I/O, 2x Mini-DP, 2x HDMI.

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